

ACTIVITY 3 — FACILITATOR GUIDE

SIPOC, Process Mapping, Handoffs, and SME Support

TYPE	DURATION	DMAIC PHASE	MAPS TO
Core Activity	60 min	DEFINE	A2, A3

Purpose of this activity

Map a process with SIPOC and a detailed process map to expose handoffs (A2, A3).

Build the macro 'as-is' view with SIPOC, then drill into a detailed process map that shows every actor, system and handoff — the points where delay and defects are actually created.

What learners produce

A completed SIPOC (5-7 steps), a swimlane process map with every handoff owned on both sides, and at least three tagged pain points.

Materials required

- Learner Worksheet (one per learner)
- Checklist (one per group)
- A laptop with Excel, Google Sheets or LibreOffice Calc
- The CSV files in this activity's data/ and templates/ folders
- Flipchart or A3 sheet and markers
- The course slides for the scenario and the framework
- A browser — this activity uses an online tool (URL in the run-sheet).

Set-up

Groups of 3-5. Distribute one worksheet per learner and one checklist per group. Every activity runs on the same continuous Contoso Service Desk scenario, so remind learners where this one sits in that story before starting.

Scenario / briefing material

Contoso Service Desk handles employee IT requests. Employees complain that tickets take too long to be assigned, that they must keep chasing for status, and that agents apply different definitions of what counts as "resolved". Handoffs between the front line and the specialist queues are unclear, and although ticket data exists it is inconsistent. You are supporting the improvement team as a Yellow Belt — you do not lead the project.

Two weeks of data have been collected: 400 tickets, of which 96 contained at least one defect, with 120 defects recorded in total across 6 defect opportunities per ticket. Mean assignment time is 55 minutes (median 46) against a 30-minute improvement goal. The CSV files in this activity's data/ folder are that extract.

Files in this activity folder

data/ — the mock data you analyse:

- process-steps.csv — 7 rows (step_no, activity, actor, system, process_time_min, wait_time_min, handoff_to)

templates/ — the worksheets you complete:

- handoff-register.csv (handoff_no, from_actor, to_actor, trigger, owner_both_sides, pain_point)
- sipoc.csv (suppliers, inputs, process_step, outputs, customers)

Open these in Excel, Google Sheets or LibreOffice Calc. Work on a copy so the originals stay clean for revision.

data/process-steps.csv holds the as-is step, actor, system and timing data.

How to run it — step by step

#	Instruction to learners	Facilitator note
1	Set the process boundaries — agree the explicit start and stop points first.	Boundaries first — without an agreed start and stop point the SIPOC sprawls.
2	Build the SIPOC with the online builder: Suppliers, Inputs, Process (5-7 high-level steps), Outputs, Customers. Tool: https://alfredang.github.io/sipoc/	Groups drift past 7 steps; make them merge rather than add.
3	Expand into a detailed process map: Step, Actor, Activity, System, Handoff.	The pain points matter more than a tidy diagram — do not let them skip step 5.
4	Assign an actor to each step — the tool generates the swimlane and detects every handoff for you.	
5	Tag pain points on the steps — waiting, rework loop, unclear ownership, duplicate entry or missing decision rule (at least three).	
6	Prepare SME notes for the Green Belt: what you observed and what needs validation.	

Suggested timing

Minutes	Phase
5 min	Agree the process boundaries
20 min	Build the SIPOC in the online builder
15 min	Expand into a detailed process map
10 min	Assign actors and detect handoffs
10 min	Tag pain points and write SME notes

Total: 60 minutes

Discussion & decision prompts

- Where exactly is the delay created — in a step, or in a handoff between steps?
- Which handoff has no clear owner on one side, and what does that cause?
- What did the process map show that the SIPOC could not?

Debrief

Bring the class back together and draw out the learning:

- Ask two or three groups to show what they produced, not just what they concluded.
- Ask what surprised them — the gap between what they assumed and what the data showed.
- Link the activity explicitly back to the DEFINE phase of DMAIC.
- Remind learners this activity rehearses what the Case Study assessment will require.

Reflection questions:

- Map one handoff in your own process — who owns each side of it?
- Where does work sit waiting in your process, and for how long?

Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Boundaries first — without an agreed start and stop point the SIPOC sprawls.
- Groups drift past 7 steps; make them merge rather than add.
- The pain points matter more than a tidy diagram — do not let them skip step 5.

Success criterion

Run 'Check my SIPOC' in the tool — all five columns populated, 5-7 steps, at least three pain points, and every handoff owned on both sides.

Assessment link

This activity builds the DEFINE phase of DMAIC. All activities are in-class activities assessed indirectly through the open-book Case Study (CS), which reuses the same techniques on the same Contoso Service Desk scenario and the same figures (400 tickets, yield 76%, DPMO 50,000). Knowledge is assessed in the Written Assessment (WA-SAQ). Nothing is assessed that is not practised here or taught in the slides.